

MAKING NETWORKING YOUR SUPERPOWER, NOT YOUR KRYPTONITE

UNLOCKING THE POWER OF NETWORKING: BENEFITS AND BARRIERS

Networking, the art of building and maintaining valuable professional relationships, has long been recognized as a cornerstone for career development and business success.

As job changes continue to become more frequent, having a strong network that can help you find your next opportunity becomes ever more critical. However, even in today's world, it yields quantifiable benefits that significantly contribute to individual and organizational growth. In this white paper, we will dive into the benefits of, and psychological barriers to, networking.



WHY NETWORK AT ALL?

First and foremost, networking enhances career opportunities.

A survey by LinkedIn revealed that up to 85% of jobs are filled through networking. This statistic underscores the critical role that personal connections play in the job market, often leading to opportunities that are not advertised publicly.

Moreover, networking fosters professional development. Interacting with peers and industry leaders exposes individuals to new ideas, practices, and technologies. This exchange of knowledge not only broadens one's perspective but also sharpens skills, making individuals more competitive and innovative. According to the American Society for Training and Development, networking with professionals outside one's immediate circle can accelerate learning and professional growth.



Financial benefits are another significant advantage of networking. For entrepreneurs, salespeople and businesses, building a strong network can lead to partnerships, investments, and sales opportunities. A report by HubSpot indicated that networking efforts account for 40% of new customer acquisitions in business, showcasing the direct impact of networking on revenue growth.

THREE TYPES OF NETWORK

These benefits from networking are, and will remain, a critical tool for anyone looking to improve career opportunities, accelerate personal development, or simply make more money. However, not all networks are created equal. According to one Harvard Business Review study, there are three types of networks.

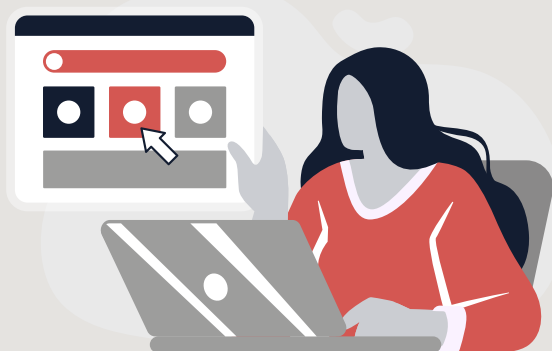
Firstly, there's an **operational network**. These are the people who help you get things done in the near term, or they're people who direct you to the people who know how to get things done. For example, instead of having to call the IT help desk, you have a contact who can help solve your issue directly. These are typically internal networks, although they can also be external to your company, depending on your role. They are useful for maximising current and near-term performance.

Secondly, there's **personal networks**. These help you advance in your careers by providing referrals, information, and developmental support (like coaching and mentoring). Personal networks can be internal or external to your firm, but generally tend to include people with whom you have things in common – that might be professional associations, alumni networks, affinity networks or clubs. Generally, because of that commonality, these are people who trust you and are willing to help you along the way, potentially greasing the wheels with an important introduction.



THREE TYPES OF NETWORK

Finally, there's the **strategic network**. Most people think they are good at networking because they have a strong personal and operational network. However, the people who use networking to really differentiate themselves are people to build strategic networks. These are networks of people outside of your immediate space, helping to give you different perspectives and a bigger picture view of the world. You may not see the results right away, but the strategic relationship that you invest in over time could pay dividends in the future, by opening an unexpected door to an exciting new opportunity.



No matter what kind of network you are aiming for, there are two things to remember. Most importantly, find commonalities with the people you meet – something that you can connect on, and that you can bring up to help connect you the next time you interact. It might be a shared interest, shared contacts, or a company that you both worked at or with. This helps create comfort, builds connection and makes it easier for your network to remember you.



PSYCHOLOGICAL BARRIERS TO NETWORKING

The other thing to remember is that it's a two-way relationship. People will suss out if you're always after something and that's the only time you reach out. Research has shown that if you give and take in your work life, then you will be more successful. Find ways to give value to your contacts, and it will repay itself over time.

Despite all these benefits, there are many for which the thought of networking evokes a cocktail of dread, anxiety, and self-doubt. The good news? You're not alone, and there are strategies to overcome these psychological barriers. Some of the most common mental blocks and how to solve them are below.

Barrier 1: Fear of Rejection

The fear of rejection is a primal one, it goes back to our evolutionary need to belong to a tribe. In a business context, this fear can stop us from reaching out, worried that our advances might be met with silence.

Strategy to overcome: Try reframing rejection. View each networking attempt as a step closer to success, not a setback. Remember, not every interaction will lead to a meaningful connection, and that's okay. It's part of the process. Embrace the numbers game and keep moving forward.





Barrier 2: Impostor Syndrome

The persistent fear of being 'found out' as not being as competent or deserving as others perceive us to be. Impostor syndrome can make the idea of networking, especially with those we admire or see as more successful, downright intimidating.

Strategy to overcome: Acknowledge your achievements and the value you bring. Impostor syndrome thrives on self-doubt. Counteract this by keeping a record of your accomplishments and positive feedback. Remember, you have unique insights and experiences that can contribute meaningfully to any conversation.



Barrier 3: Introversion and Social Anxiety

For introverts or those with social anxiety, networking can feel overwhelming, with the pressure to make small talk and meet new people seeming insurmountable.

Strategy to overcome: Leverage your strengths. Introverts often excel in one-on-one or small group interactions because of their propensity for deep listening and meaningful conversation. Focus on creating quality connections rather than quantity. Additionally, consider online networking platforms where initial interactions may feel less daunting.





Barrier 4: Uncertainty

Uncertainty can come from many sources, including previous negative experiences, or simply not knowing where to start. This can lead to procrastination and the avoidance of networking opportunities altogether.

Strategy to overcome: Start small and prepare. Begin with less intimidating networking situations, such as online forums or industry-specific meetups where the environment is more controlled and familiar. Also, arm yourself with conversation starters and practice your pitch. The more prepared you are, the more confident you'll feel.



UNIVERSAL STRATEGIES FOR OVERCOMING BARRIERS

There are also several overall strategies that can help no matter what your barrier is:

1. Shift your mindset: View networking as a learning opportunity and a chance to help others, rather than a self-serving activity. Think what I can contribute rather than what have I got to gain. This perspective can change the emotional stakes and reduce the pressure.

2. Set Realistic Goals: Instead of aiming to meet everyone at an event or contact 20 key decision makers this week, set a goal to have/set up meaningful conversations with a few people. Quality over quantity can lead to more fulfilling and less stressful networking experiences.

3. Follow-Up: The magic of networking often happens in the follow-up. Sending a personalized message or note after meeting someone can cement the initial connection and open the door to further interaction.

4. Practice Self-Compassion: Be kind to yourself. Networking is a skill that improves with practice. Celebrate small victories and learn from experiences without harsh self-judgment.



As we've seen, networking has the power to make you more effective, more successful, and better paid. Challenging yourself to overcome your barriers to networking is critical to career success. Take your first step and sign up to a networking event today.



USA

Hatwell Group

41 Ellth Street

11th Floor

New York, NY 10003

Tel : **+1 800 778 7098**

UK & Europe

Hatwell Group

Connect House

133-37 Alexandra House

Wimbledon, United Kingdom

SW19 7JU

Tel : **+44 7944858211**